

Reflections on College Life and Life After: What I Would've Said If I Were
Commencement Speaker

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People like to say that college is the best 4 years of your life. In many ways, I can imagine why. Walking to class and seeing your friends, playing in stadiums even though you're not on the competitive team, living within walking distance of everyone and everything you love... but I refuse to believe this is true.

College is so special because of the bubble it creates. Our social and professional lives all revolve around one central campus, and what makes UCLA even more special is how alive of a city LA is. Graduating means moving beyond this bubble into a world where, suddenly, it takes so much more effort to get to the places you want to be.

More importantly, though, leaving here is scary because we're no longer surrounded by people we share something in common with. We're not all united by the fact that we go to the same school, that we're members of the same club, that we're part of the same IM or club team. It feels like there'll be less of those moments where you realize this random person in front of you is mutuals with your old roommate, a class friend, or a club buddy. Suddenly, strangers really feel like strangers, not people you could someday be close friends with.

But the funny thing is, there's gonna be new grads everywhere now. Look around the room! There's thousands of other people heading into the same situation as yourself. And we're all just engineers — think about how many grads from other majors there'll be. And all the other grads from every other university! We'll be all over the world, which is tough, but that also means there'll certainly be community to be found wherever it is we land.

The world beyond college feels scary because of what we don't know about the people we don't know. Strangers in the real world aren't like strangers at UCLA, where you have some sense that mostly everyone is safe and will look out for you

even if they don't know you. But who's to say we can't carry this attitude with us into life beyond college?

There's this YouTube channel I used to be obsessed with, this channel called Yes Theory. And the point of Yes Theory isn't to just blindly say yes to everything in life, but rather that saying yes to those things in life that make us uncomfortable can lead to some of the most fulfilling experiences. Not just anything uncomfortable, but to those things that create that type of discomfort that comes with trying something new, meeting new people, or learning a new skill.

It's realistically pretty hard to get into new things. But, take a second to think about this. Everything that represents you today, everything that's important to you, everything that's a priority to you, is there because at some point you decided to let it into your life. Whether that's a sport, a skill, a career — it doesn't matter. The point is that at some point, this core part of your identity was never a part of you.

At our age now, we have a sense of what fulfills us in life. But that doesn't mean there's no space for what's yet to be discovered. Having an open mind and pushing past that discomfort of doing something you normally don't, or have never done, is worth all the new friendships, experiences, values, and joy that come with exploring new parts of life that are a core part of other people's identities.

So, I hope as we move on from our time here, we all remember to cherish those we have in our lives, while offering graciousness to those we have yet to meet. To enjoy our hobbies, while finding new ones. To look back on our time in college as a great few years, and to look forward to the rest of our lives as an unpredictable, but exciting time. With so much yet to be discovered and so many friendships yet to be made, it's my wish that everyone here finds happiness and joy in the next chapter of our lives.